

QA LEADERSHIP ACADEMY

AI Adoption Roadmap

Move from informal, ungoverned AI use to deliberate, governed adoption in phases leadership can trust.

Purpose

This roadmap sequences a QA function's AI adoption from an ungoverned starting point to deliberate, governed, value-driven use. It puts governance and safe quick wins before ambitious use cases, so that adoption builds trust rather than incidents. Each phase has an outcome, the controls it depends on, and a measure — because responsible adoption is a programme, not a single announcement.

When to use it

- When AI use is happening informally and you need a credible plan to govern and grow it.
- When leadership asks for an AI strategy for QA and you want a staged, defensible answer.
- To connect the other AI tools — Use-Case Matrix, Risk Assessment, Governance Checklist, Pilot — into one journey.

Instructions

1. Locate your true starting point honestly (usually "informal use, no policy").
2. Sequence phases so basic governance comes before expansion — never scale on top of no controls.
3. For each phase, state the outcome, the controls it depends on, and how you will measure it.
4. Tie each phase to the supporting tools (matrix, risk assessment, checklist, pilot).
5. Gate each phase: only advance when its controls and measures are met, and review as tools and regulation change.

Worked example

A staged adoption roadmap for Northstar, starting from informal use of public AI tools with no policy. Timescales are indicative planning estimates:

Phase	Outcome	Controls it depends on	Measure
0 · Contain (weeks 1–2)	Stop the risky bleed	Two written rules: no source code, no PII in public tools; name accountability	Rules issued and acknowledged by the team

Phase	Outcome	Controls it depends on	Measure
1 · Govern (weeks 2-6)	A workable policy	Approved-tools list; Governance Checklist mostly in place; defer legal/privacy to owners	Governance Checklist gaps closing; a route to raise concerns
2 · Safe wins (Q2)	Value from low-risk uses	Use-Case Matrix done; human review mandatory	One or two adopted uses with a positive, measured pilot
3 · Controlled pilots (Q2-Q3)	Evidence on higher-value uses	Risk Assessment per use; Pilot Template with guardrails	Go / no-go verdicts recorded; guardrails held
4 · Scale & sustain (Q3+)	Governed, routine use	Periodic checklist review; skills-protection in place	Sustained value; no governance incidents; juniors' skills protected

The order is deliberate and matches Northstar's reality: Phase 0 stops the live IP/PII exposure immediately, before anything ambitious is attempted. Only once basic governance exists (Phase 1) does adoption expand to safe wins and then controlled pilots. This directly answers a CTO who wants "more AI" without a definition — it delivers value early while making the risk visibly managed.

GOVERN BEFORE YOU GROW

Adoption that outruns governance produces the incident that sets AI adoption back a year. Phase 0 and 1 exist so growth stands on controls, not luck.

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Phase	Outcome	Controls it depends on	Measure
0 · Contain			
1 · Govern			
2 · Safe wins			
3 · Controlled pilots			
4 · Scale & sustain			

Common mistakes

COMMON MISTAKES

Jumping to ambitious use cases before any governance exists; issuing a blanket ban that drives use underground; a roadmap that is all policy and never delivers a real win, so people disengage; ignoring skills erosion as adoption scales; and setting no phase gates, so containment and governance are quietly skipped in the rush to "do AI".

How to interpret the results

- If your honest starting point is Phase 0, that is not a failure — most organisations start with informal use; naming it is the first control.
- A roadmap that reaches "scale" before governance is complete is the classic recipe for the incident that stalls adoption.

- Early phases are measured by controls in place; later phases by sustained, incident-free value — do not judge Phase 0 on productivity.
- Progress is fewer governance gaps and steady, measured wins over time — not the number of AI tools in use.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

When an executive asks for "more AI" with no definition — as Northstar's CTO does — do not argue about the destination. Show this roadmap. Phase 0 gives them speed of action, Phase 1 gives them safety, and the later phases give them the value they were really asking for. A staged answer beats both a reckless yes and a cautious no.